

GRADE 7 · READING INFORMATIONAL TEXT · RI.7.8

Tracing and Evaluating Arguments

Trace the argument and specific claims in an argumentative text about extending the school year, assess whether the reasoning is sound and the evidence is relevant and sufficient, and evaluate the overall strength of the argument.

Lesson Map · Passage · Guided · Partner · Independent Practice · Small Group · Answer Key

What You Will Learn Today

Learning Goals

Understand RI.7.8: Trace the argument and specific claims in an argumentative text about ...

Read an original passage closely

Support every answer with text evidence

Work through guided, partner, and independent practice

How the Lesson Runs

Warm-up and passage

Guided practice together

Partner discussion

Independent + small-group work

Exit ticket and answer key

Unpacking the Standard

An argument is a central claim supported by reasons and evidence. Sound reasoning means each step logically connects to the next. Relevant evidence directly supports the specific claim being made; sufficient evidence means there is enough of it to be convincing, not just one example.

Modeled Example

Claim: "Our school should add a recycling program." Evidence: "My cousin's school has one." Is this evidence relevant and sufficient?

It is relevant (it relates to the claim) but not sufficient — one example from one other school is not enough evidence to strongly support a claim for a policy change.

Claim: "Homework should be reduced." Evidence: "A study of 500 students found reduced homework correlated with better sleep and similar test scores." Is this evidence relevant and sufficient?

Yes — it is directly relevant to the claim and, with a reasonably large sample size and specific findings, provides more sufficient support than a single anecdote would.

Should the School Year Be Longer?

1. Every summer, students lose an estimated one to two months of reading skill, a phenomenon researchers call the "summer slide." Teachers spend the first several weeks of each fall reviewing material students have partially forgotten, effectively repeating instruction that already happened the previous spring. Extending the school year would substantially reduce this wasted repetition and should be adopted nationwide.
2. Consider the numbers: a school year extended by four weeks, spread across the current ten-week summer break, would leave summer at six weeks — enough for a meaningful break while significantly narrowing the learning-loss window. Districts that have already piloted extended calendars report students returning from break with measurably smaller skill gaps than students on a traditional calendar.
3. Critics argue that extending the school year would increase costs: more days of staffing, utilities, and transportation. This is a fair concern, but it overlooks that the current system already carries a hidden cost — teachers spending weeks re-teaching lost material is not free instructional time; it is time paid for twice.
4. Other critics point to the importance of summer for family time, camps, and unstructured childhood play. These experiences matter, and a four-week extension, not year-round schooling, would preserve six weeks of summer while still shortening the learning-loss window meaningfully.

Should the School Year Be Longer?, continued

5. One pilot district extended its calendar by four weeks in 2019 and tracked outcomes for three years. Students showed a 15 percent smaller drop in reading assessment scores over the summer compared to the three years before the change, and teachers reported needing roughly two fewer weeks of fall review.

6. The evidence points in one clear direction: shortening summer break, even modestly, measurably reduces learning loss without eliminating summer's benefits. Schools that have not yet made this change are choosing a familiar calendar over a demonstrated improvement.

Warm-up · Before You Read

1. What is the central claim of this argument?

2. What is the first piece of evidence given to support this claim, in paragraph 1?

Guided Practice

3. Is that first piece of evidence relevant to the claim? Explain.

4. What claim does paragraph 3 respond to, and how does it respond?

Guided Practice

5. Is the reasoning in paragraph 3 sound? Explain your evaluation.

6. What claim does paragraph 4 respond to, and how does it respond?

Partner Discussion

7. Is the evidence in paragraph 4 sufficient to fully address the concern about family time? Explain.

8. What specific evidence does paragraph 5 provide, and is it relevant to the central claim?

Partner Discussion

9. Is the evidence in paragraph 5 sufficient on its own to support extending the school year nationwide? Explain.

Independent Practice

10. What conclusion does paragraph 6 draw, and does it logically follow from the evidence presented?

11. Identify one specific claim in the argument and evaluate whether its evidence is relevant.

Independent Practice

12. Identify one specific claim in the argument and evaluate whether its evidence is sufficient.

13. Does the author acknowledge opposing viewpoints? Cite evidence.

Independent Practice

14. Why is acknowledging opposing viewpoints generally a sign of sound reasoning?

15. Is the claim in paragraph 6 ("schools that have not yet made this change are choosing a familiar calendar over a demonstrated improvement") a fair conclusion based on the evidence? Explain.

Small-Group Work

16. What additional evidence would make the overall argument stronger?

17. Evaluate whether the reasoning connecting summer learning loss (paragraph 1) to the proposed four-week extension (paragraph 2) is logical.

Small-Group Work

18. Overall, is this argument's evidence sufficient to fully convince you the school year should be extended nationwide? Explain your evaluation.

19. How does the author's use of a specific number ("15 percent smaller drop") strengthen the argument compared to a vague claim like "students did better"?

Exit Ticket

20. Identify one specific claim, then evaluate both whether its reasoning is sound and whether its evidence is relevant and sufficient.

Answer Key (1 of 4)

1. That the school year should be extended (by about four weeks) because doing so would substantially reduce summer learning loss.
2. Students lose an estimated one to two months of reading skill over the summer, requiring teachers to spend weeks re-teaching material each fall.
3. Yes — it directly relates to the claim, since the summer learning loss it describes is the exact problem the proposed extension is meant to solve.
4. It responds to the claim that extending the school year would increase costs, arguing that the current system already has a hidden cost: paying teachers to re-teach lost material.
5. It is reasonably sound — it directly addresses the cost concern by reframing an existing cost (repeated instruction) as evidence the added cost may be partly offset, rather than ignoring the concern.

Answer Key (2 of 4)

6. It responds to the concern that summer is important for family time and unstructured play, arguing that a four-week extension still preserves six weeks of summer.

7. It is only partially sufficient — it shows some summer is preserved, but it does not provide evidence (such as a study or survey) about whether six weeks is actually enough time for meaningful family activities, which weakens this part of the argument.

8. A pilot district's three-year data showing a 15 percent smaller drop in reading scores and two fewer weeks of fall review after extending the calendar — this is directly relevant, since it provides a real-world test of the central claim.

9. It is meaningful evidence, but it comes from a single pilot district over three years — evaluating whether that is sufficient for a nationwide claim requires considering whether one district's results would generalize to different schools and communities.

10. It concludes that shortening summer break "measurably reduces learning loss without eliminating summer's benefits" — this follows reasonably from the pilot data in paragraph 5, though it may overstate certainty based on evidence from only one district.

Answer Key (3 of 4)

11. Answers vary; for example, the claim that costs are a "hidden cost already" (paragraph 3) is relevant to the cost objection, since it directly addresses spending on instructional time.

12. Answers vary; for example, the claim in paragraph 2 that piloted districts show "measurably smaller skill gaps" is not fully sufficient on its own, since no specific numbers or district names are given in that sentence, unlike the more detailed data in paragraph 5.

13. Yes — paragraph 3 acknowledges the cost concern ("This is a fair concern") and paragraph 4 acknowledges the value of family time and play ("These experiences matter").

14. It shows the author has considered other perspectives and is responding to real concerns rather than ignoring them, which tends to make an argument more balanced and credible.

15. This is debatable — while the pilot data supports some improvement, the phrase "demonstrated improvement" may overstate certainty since the evidence comes from only one district's three-year experience, not a broader or more rigorous study.

Answer Key (4 of 4)

16. Data from multiple districts or a larger, more diverse study, rather than a single pilot district, would make the case for a nationwide policy more convincing.

17. It is logical in its basic structure — if learning loss happens during a ten-week break, shortening that break by four weeks reasonably could reduce the amount of loss — though it assumes the relationship between break length and learning loss is roughly proportional, which is not explicitly proven.

18. Answers vary; require an evaluation that references specific evidence from the text (such as the single-district pilot data) and explains why it either does or does not feel sufficient for a nationwide claim.

19. Specific, measurable data is more convincing and harder to dismiss than a vague claim, since it gives readers a concrete result they can evaluate rather than a general impression.

20. Answers vary; require a specific claim from the text, an evaluation of its logical soundness, and an evaluation of its evidence's relevance and sufficiency, with reasoning supported by the text.

Exit Ticket

Answer on a sticky note

Answer the exit-ticket question from today's lesson.

Cite at least one piece of evidence from the passage.

Remember

Name your claim or answer

Quote or cite the evidence

Explain how it supports your answer